decreases with **altitude**. The major layers extending from the Earth's surface to outer space are illustrated below.

Altitude: The height of a location above mean sea level is called altitude, usually measured in metres or feet. The mean sea level is considered zero.

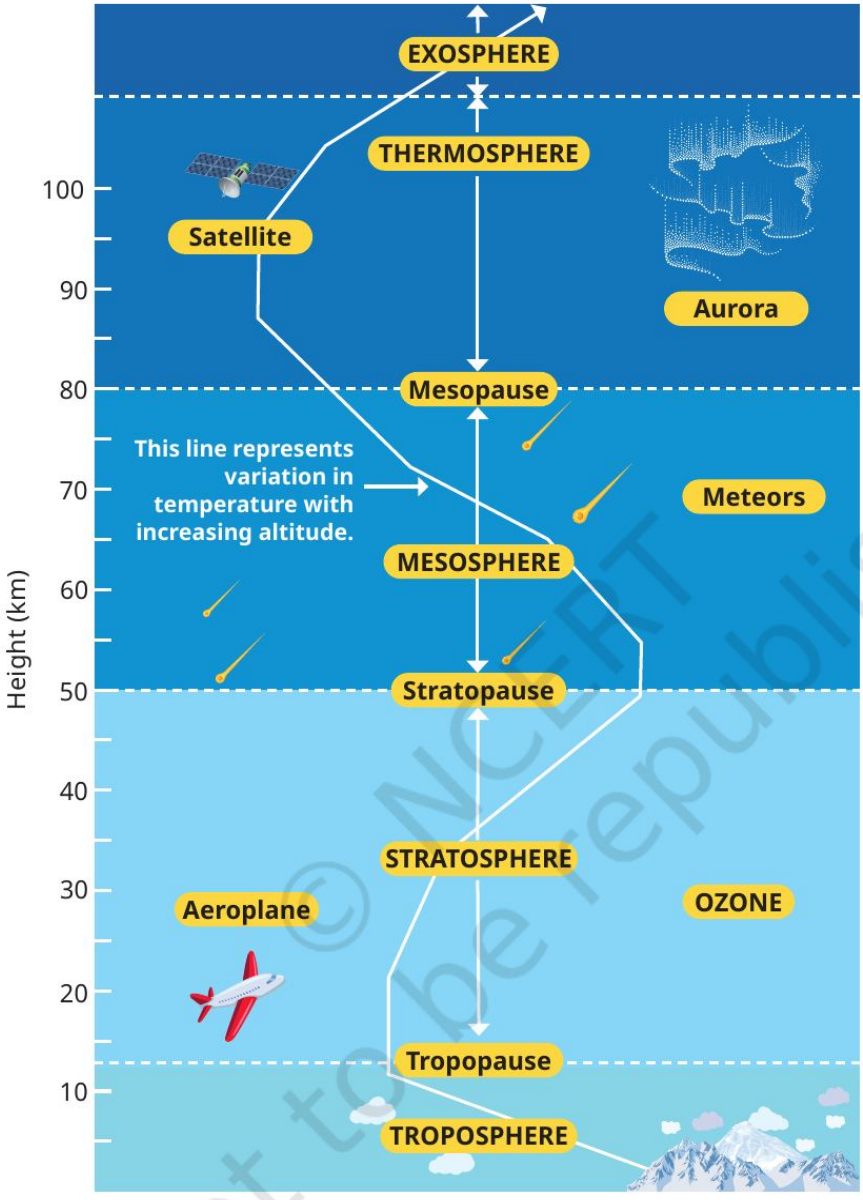


Fig. 3.3. Layers of the atmosphere

- **Troposphere:** The troposphere is the most important layer of the atmosphere, with an average height of about 12 kilometres. In this layer, temperature decreases with increasing altitude. The air we breathe exists here, along with most of the water vapour and clouds. Nearly all the weather phenomena, such as rainfall, fog, and hail, occur in this layer. The troposphere is separated from the stratosphere by a transition zone known as the tropopause.

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